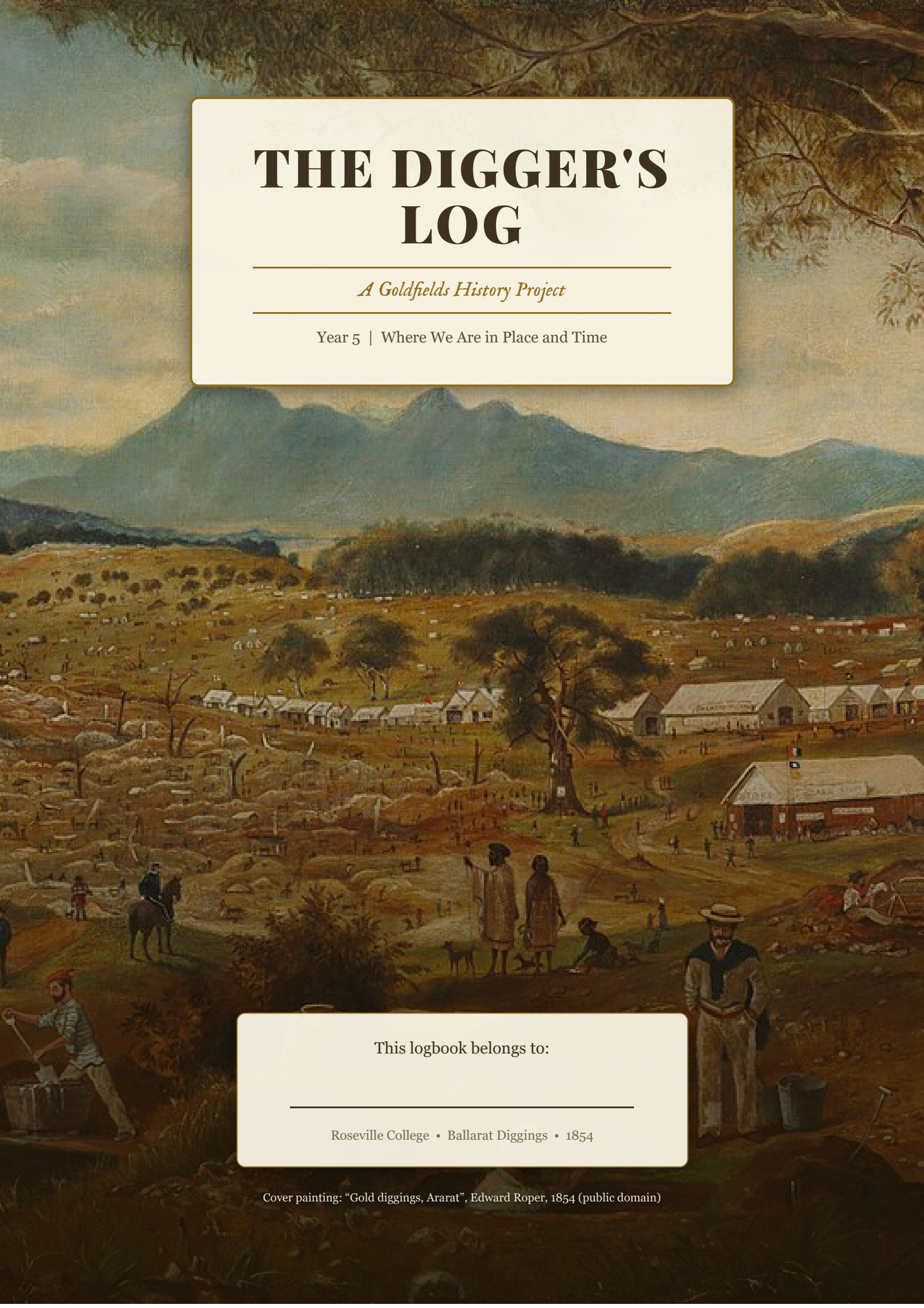




THE DIGGER'S LOG

A Goldfields History Project

Year 5 | Where We Are in Place and Time

This logbook belongs to:

Roseville College • Ballarat Diggings • 1854

Cover painting: "Gold diggings, Ararat", Edward Roper, 1854 (public domain)

Contents

Everything in your Digger's Log, in order.

Section	Week	What you will do
Project overview	For families	Read together, sign
My goldfields identity	Week 7	Create your character
Entry 1: Dig for evidence	Week 7	Comprehension + story plan
Entry 2: Write your story	Week 8	Narrative + comprehension
Entry 3: Another pair of eyes	Week 9	Comprehension + diary
The Source Pack	Any week	Facts to mine for your writing

How this booklet works

Every week begins with reading and questions, because that is how historians work: **evidence first, writing second.** Your answers are not just answers. They are gold nuggets of information, and each week they unlock the next task. Guard them well; you will need them.

The rule of the diggings: you cannot write about the goldfields until you have dug up the facts. Every story, diary and reflection in this booklet must be built from real evidence you have collected.



SOURCE DETECTIVE: “An Australian Gold Diggings”, oil painting by an unknown artist, about 1855. Look closely: who can you find besides the diggers? Who do you think it was painted for?

Your mission

Welcome to the year 1854. For the next three weeks you will live a second life on the Australian goldfields. You will create a character, dig up evidence about how people really lived, write the story of your character's most dramatic day, and then live that *same day* again through completely different eyes. By the end, you will understand something historians know well: the same day on the same diggings was a different story for every person who lived it.

Your mission timeline

Done	Entry	Week	What you will create
☐	1. Dig for evidence	Week 7	Two short readings with questions, your Evidence Pouch, and a story plan.
☐	2. Write your story	Week 8	A narrative starring your digger, built from your evidence, plus one more reading.
☐	3. Another pair of eyes	Week 9	A final reading, then a diary entry for the same day, written by a different person.

A note for families

The booklet comes home on a Friday, and that week's entry is due the following Thursday. Each entry needs roughly 45 to 60 minutes, best spread across two or three sittings rather than one night. Week 8 is the biggest week (the story), so please help your child start it early. The comprehension answers each week are deliberately recycled into the writing tasks, so encourage your child to answer in full sentences and in her own words; she is building her own source material. Everything needed is inside this booklet, including a Source Pack of real facts at the back. No internet research is required, and nothing is typed: all writing is done by hand in the booklet, in your child's best cursive.

Central idea: *History can be viewed from a variety of perspectives.*

Family acknowledgement

I have seen the Digger's Log project and understand what my child will be doing each week.

Parent / carer name: _____ Signature: _____ Date: _____



SOURCE DETECTIVE: "Canvas Town", South Melbourne, 1850s. Thousands of new arrivals lived in tent cities like this before setting out for the diggings. What can this picture tell us? What can't it?

Who will you be?

Before you can write about the diggings, you must belong to them. Create your goldfields identity below and **keep it for all three weeks**. You can be a digger, or the wife, son or daughter of one. The year is 1854, and you are on the Ballarat diggings.

— IDENTITY PAPERS —

My name on the diggings: _____

My age: _____ **I am a:** digger / digger's wife / child on the diggings (*circle one*)

I sailed from: England · Ireland · Scotland · China · Germany · America · somewhere else:

I have been on the diggings for: _____ months

Who came with me, and who I left behind:

Why we came:

In my swag I carry... (*choose three, and add one of your own*)

a tin pannikin

a letter from home

a gold pan

a bag of flour

a Bible

a fiddle

a photograph

a pocket knife

a sewing kit

a bamboo shoulder pole

a chest of tea from home

an abacus

a jade charm

a wide bamboo hat

my own: _____

My greatest hope and my greatest fear

A secret for Week 9: your identity is only one pair of eyes on these diggings. In the final week you will borrow somebody else's, so as you read and write, keep noticing the people your character walks past every day.

Reading 1: Daily life on the goldfields

Read carefully, then answer in full sentences. Remember: every answer is a nugget you will need for your Evidence Pouch. Starting this before our first gold lessons in class? Even better: everything you need is on this page, and you will walk into our gold lessons already knowing the diggings.

Daily life on the Australian goldfields was challenging. Miners usually lived in tents or crude huts made from canvas, bark, or slabs of wood. In winter, the diggings turned into seas of mud, while in summer dust storms covered everything. Hygiene was poor, and many miners became sick from diseases such as dysentery and typhoid. Fresh food was expensive and often scarce. In Bendigo, an egg could cost sixpence (about \$7 today), while butter could cost over a pound per kilogram (around \$200 today).

Work was back-breaking. Most miners dug and panned for 10–12 hours a day, often in harsh weather. Tools like pans and picks wore out quickly, and many miners found only small flakes of gold. Very few struck rich finds. Most diggers earned no more than £2–3 a week (around \$300–450 today), about the same as a farm labourer. Despite the tough conditions, the dream of sudden wealth kept people on the fields.



SOURCE DETECTIVE: “Canvas Town”, painted by S.T. Gill in 1852. Gill lived on the diggings and sketched what he saw. Find two details in this picture that match the text above.

1. Describe two challenges miners faced in their daily lives.

2. Why was food so expensive on the goldfields?

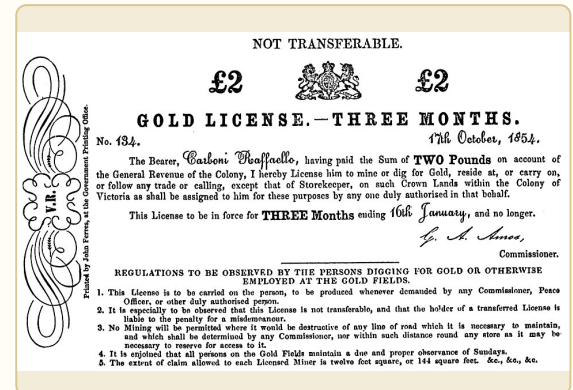
3. How much did most miners earn each week, and how does this compare to today's money?

4. What kept many miners working despite the difficult conditions?

Reading 2: Miners' licences

To control the rush for gold, colonial governments introduced the miners' licence. This required all diggers to pay 30 shillings each month (about \$350 today), whether or not they found any gold.

Licences had to be carried at all times and shown on demand. Police, known as “licence hunters,” often checked papers harshly, searching camps and arresting those who could not pay. Punishments included heavy fines or even time in jail. Many miners felt the system was unfair, as it taxed the poor and successful alike. Anger over the licence fees led to protests and, in 1854, helped spark the Eureka Stockade at Ballarat, one of the most famous uprisings in Australian history.



SOURCE DETECTIVE: a real gold licence. This scrap of paper cost 30 shillings a month. Imagine being asked to produce it while waist-deep in a mud hole.

5. How much did a miner's licence cost each month, and what would that be in today's money?

6. Why did many miners think the licence system was unfair?

7. Who were the “licence hunters”, and what powers did they have?

8. How did the licence system lead to conflict on the goldfields?

Your Evidence Pouch

You have just dug up eight answers. Now turn them into story gold. Choose **at least five facts** from your answers (or the readings) and drop each one into your pouch below. Beside each fact, jot how it could appear in your story. In Week 8, **at least three of these nuggets must be woven into your narrative**. The first one is done for you.



REAL GOLD from the Victorian fields.

Gold nugget (a real fact)	How it could appear in my story
An egg cost sixpence, about \$7 today.	Ma sighs at the storekeeper's prices, and we go without eggs again this week.

Plan your story

Next week you will write the story of your digger's most dramatic day. Choose your big moment now (circle one, or invent your own):

a licence hunt

striking gold at last

sickness comes to the tent

a flood or dust storm

a theft in the night

bad news from home

my own idea: _____

Story mountain

Opening *(an ordinary morning on the diggings; show us your character's world):*

Build-up *(the first sign that today is different):*

Climax *(your big moment):*

Resolution *(what happens straight after):*

Ending *(that night: what has changed, and how does your character feel?):*

Before you finish Week 7, check that you...

- ☐ Read both texts and answered all eight questions in full sentences.
- ☐ Collected at least five nuggets in your Evidence Pouch.
- ☐ Chose your big moment and planned your story on the story mountain.

★ Going further (for historians who want a challenge)

Interview a grown-up at home: if your family had to pack for the diggings tomorrow, carrying everything on your backs, what three things would they refuse to leave behind, and why? Jot their answers below. You might smuggle one into your story.

Write your story

This week you write a narrative about your digger's most dramatic day on the diggings, following the plan you made in Week 7. It is make-believe, but it must be grounded in real history: weave **at least three nuggets from your Evidence Pouch** into the story, so your reader learns something true while they are swept along.

Keep it grounded. Be imaginative, but make it unmistakably the Australian goldfields of the 1850s, with its real prices, real hardships and real hopes. A story that could happen in any old place is not finished yet.

Your writer's toolkit

You sharpened these four tools in your Star Log. Now use them in a new world. Write one of each, ready to drop into your story.

Figurative language

A simile uses "like" or "as"; a metaphor says one thing IS another; personification gives objects human actions.

The mud gripped our cart like a greedy hand. The diggings were an anthill of men. The wind worried at our tent all night.

Sensory writing

Help your reader see, hear, smell and feel the scene.

Rain drummed on the canvas, the air smelled of wet ash, and cold mud crept between my toes.

Appositives

An extra phrase that renames or adds detail to a noun, tucked between two commas.

Ballarat, a city of calico tents, spread across the valley below us.

Adverbial phrases

Tells when, where or how something happens. Try starting a sentence with one.

Before the sun rose over the diggings, Pa was already at the windlass. Without a sound, the trooper lifted our tent flap.



STORY FUEL: diggers working a puddling machine at Bendigo. Steal a detail: the creak of the wheel, the slap of wet clay, the horse plodding in circles.

Sentence starters

Stuck on how to begin, or how to keep the story moving? Borrow one of these and make it your own. Change the words so they fit your character: they are springboards, not lines to copy.

ARRIVING AND EVERYDAY LIFE

- After five weeks on the road from Sydney, we finally saw the smoke of a thousand campfires.
- Nothing at home had prepared me for the noise of the diggings.
- The first sound I heard every morning was the thud of picks, like a great heartbeat under the earth.

THE LICENCE HUNT

- “Traps! Traps!” The cry ran down the gully like fire through dry grass.
- Pa's hand went to his empty pocket, and my heart went cold.
- The trooper's shadow fell across our tent flap before we heard his boots.

STRIKING IT LUCKY

- At first I thought it was a trick of the light.
- Pa came up the shaft shouting, and every pick in the gully fell silent.
- It was no bigger than a bird's egg, but it changed everything.

HARD TIMES

- The rain had not stopped for six days, and the diggings had become a sea of mud.
- That winter, the sickness came to our end of the gully.
- We had eaten mutton and damper for so long that I dreamed of my grandmother's kitchen.

FOR ANY STORY

- I will never forget the day the diggings showed us what it could give, and what it could take.
- If you had been there, you would have held your breath too.
- Ma always said the goldfields gave with one hand and took with the other.



SOURCE DETECTIVE: Edward Hargraves, painted by Thomas Balcombe in 1851, the year gold was announced at Ophir. Hargraves paid for pictures like this. How might that change what they show?

Before you draft: open your Evidence Pouch and put a star beside the three nuggets you will weave in. Keep your story mountain beside you as you write.

Entry 2: Write your story | Year 5 Home Learning

Name: _____

Write your first draft

*Use your plan and your toolkit sentences. Show, don't tell, and weave in your three nuggets as you go. **Do NOT type your story.** Write it by hand, in your best cursive, straight onto these pages.*

Title: _____

[illegible]

THE DIGGER'S LOG

WEEK 8

Entry 2: Write your story | Year 5 Home Learning

Name: _____

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue or grey ruling lines, typical of notebook paper. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Aim to finish your story on these two pages: good writers edit, cutting the sections that earn their place least. If you absolutely need a third page, staple it into the booklet.

Before you finish your story, check that you...

- ☐ Set your story on the goldfields of the 1850s, starring your digger identity.
 - ☐ Wove in at least three real nuggets from your Evidence Pouch.
 - ☐ Have a beginning, a problem (your big moment), and an ending.
 - ☐ Used a simile, metaphor or personification.
 - ☐ Used sensory detail (see, hear, smell, feel).
 - ☐ Used an appositive and an adverbial phrase.
 - ☐ Wrote it by hand, in cursive, on these pages.
 - ☐ Read it aloud to check it flows.

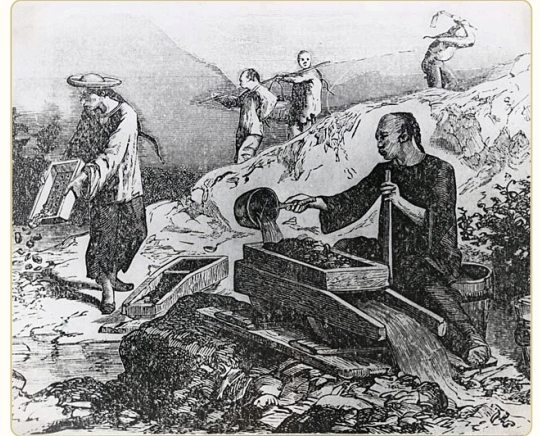
Reading 3: Migrants on the goldfields

One more dig before the week ends. This reading unlocks Week 9, so read it closely.

The gold rush brought people from all over the world to Australia. By the mid-1850s, Victoria's population had tripled, and migrants made up a large part of the goldfield population. Thousands arrived from Britain, Ireland, Germany, and America. By 1857, there were more than 25,000 Chinese miners in Victoria, making them the largest non-European group on the fields.

Chinese miners often worked patiently in large groups, reworking ground that Europeans had abandoned. They sometimes found good amounts of gold this way. However, they faced racism, extra taxes, and sometimes violence from European diggers who disliked their customs. In 1857, at Buckland River in Victoria, a riot drove hundreds of Chinese miners from their camps.

For Indigenous Australians, the gold rush was devastating. Lands were dug up, rivers polluted, and sacred sites destroyed. Many Indigenous communities were pushed off their land and found it harder to survive.



SOURCE DETECTIVE: Chinese gold miners, photographed in the 1800s. Photographs took minutes to expose, so people had to stand very still. Is this a candid moment, or a posed one? How does that change what it tells us?

1. How many Chinese miners were in Victoria by 1857?

2. How did Chinese miners work differently from Europeans?

3. What challenges did Chinese miners face on the goldfields?

4. How did the gold rush affect Indigenous Australians?

5. Why do you think the gold rush is seen as the start of Australia's multicultural society?

Entry 2: Write your story | Year 5 Home Learning

Name: _____

You have unlocked Week 9

Next week, you will spend one day on the diggings in someone else's boots. Not just any day: the *very same day* as your story. While your digger was living their big moment, thousands of other lives were going on all around them. Choose now whose eyes you will borrow:

- ☐ A Chinese miner, reworking an abandoned claim nearby
- ☐ A woman keeping her family, and perhaps a small business, going
- ☐ A child on the diggings, working and playing between the tents

Choose eyes that are different from your own character's. If your digger is already one of these, pick another.

I chose this person because...

Gather your first clues

From Reading 3 and your answers, jot down 3 things you already know about your chosen person's life, 2 things you wonder about them, and 1 question you hope the next reading answers.

3 things I know:

2 things I wonder:

1 question for next week:



Reading 4: Services on the goldfields

Your final dig. This reading, your Week 8 answers and the Source Pack at the back are the evidence for your diary entry.

Not everyone on the goldfields searched for gold. Many people made a living by providing services to miners. Shopkeepers sold food, clothes, and tools at high prices. A loaf of bread might cost two shillings (about \$45 today), and a simple meal at a goldfield restaurant could cost more than most miners earned in a day. Some businesspeople became wealthy by selling supplies, even when miners failed to find gold.

Women often ran small businesses on the diggings. They baked bread, cooked meals, washed clothes, or ran boarding houses. A successful store or hotel could earn far more than most miners. Children also contributed, carrying water, selling firewood, or helping in family businesses.

Services were essential because mining camps grew quickly into bustling communities. Places like Ballarat and Bendigo expanded from small settlements into towns with shops, theatres, and even newspapers. In this way, the gold rush helped create lasting towns and cities, not just temporary camps.

1. Give two examples of services provided on the goldfields.

2. How much could a loaf of bread cost, and what would that be in today's money?

3. How did women and children contribute to goldfield communities?

4. Why were services just as important as mining itself?

5. How did services help turn camps into lasting towns and cities?

A voice from 1853

Before you write as somebody from the past, listen to one. In 1852, a young Englishwoman named Ellen Clacy visited the diggings and published a book about what she saw. This letter is based on her account.

Life here is a strange and trying affair. Our home is a simple tent, the floor a patchwork of rough-sawn timber and packed earth. The wind and the dust are constant intruders, and the sun beats down with a relentless fury. My days are a blur of chores: fetching water from the creek, mending clothes, preparing meals over an open fire.

The sound of the diggings is a constant companion: the rhythmic thud of the pick, the rattle of the cradle, the boisterous shouts of the men. I have even tried my hand at panning. It is back-breaking work, but there is a thrill in sifting through the river gravel, a flicker of hope with every swirl of the pan.

Based on "A Lady's Visit to the Gold Diggings of Australia in 1852-53" by Ellen Clacy, published 1853.

Read like a historian

1. What jobs fill Eleanor's day? List them.

2. Find one sentence that shows both hardship AND hope at the same time, and copy it here.

3. This letter was written by a well-off English visitor. Whose voices from the diggings do we NOT hear in it?



Plan your diary entry

Now build your chosen person's day. Mine your Week 8 and Week 9 answers and the Source Pack for real details.

My person is: _____

What work fills their day?

What do they worry about? What do they hope for?

One thing they notice on the diggings that my digger never would:

Three real facts from my answers or the Source Pack that I will include:



LOOK AGAIN: the same painting from page 2. Now that you know the diggings better, find your chosen person in it. What are they doing while the diggers dig?

Entry 3: Another pair of eyes | Year 5 Home Learning

Name: _____

Write the diary entry

The task: write the diary your chosen person might have kept for the **same day as your Week 8 story**. Somewhere on the diggings, your digger's big moment happened. Did your person even notice? Was something else far more important to them that day? Write in the first person (“I”), in their voice, weaving in your three facts.

Ballarat diggings, 1854. Dear Diary...

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue or grey ruling lines, typical of notebook paper. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Before you finish, check that you...

- ☐ Wrote as your chosen person, in the first person, about the same day as your story.
 - ☐ Showed what they did, worried about and hoped for.
 - ☐ Wove in at least three real facts from your answers or the Source Pack.
 - ☐ Read it aloud in their voice.

Same diggings, different lives

You have now lived one day on the goldfields twice, through two very different pairs of eyes. Time to think like a historian.

1. What is something your digger and your Week 9 person would completely disagree about, and why?
2. If a historian found only your digger's story, what would they never learn about that day on the diggings?
3. Our central idea says history can be viewed from a variety of perspectives. Using your two characters as evidence, explain what this means in your own words.

★ **Going further (for historians who want a challenge).** Imagine two newspapers reported your digger's big moment the next morning. Write the headline each would print, then decide: which is closer to “the truth”, or do we need both?

THE DIGGERS' ADVOCATE

BALLARAT · 1854 · PRICE 3D · FRIEND OF THE MINER

Your sympathetic headline:

THE GOVERNMENT GAZETTE

MELBOURNE · 1854 · BY AUTHORITY · ORDER & LAW

Your government paper's headline:

Which headline is closer to “the truth”? Or do we need both?

Congratulations, your Digger's Log is complete. Bring it to school for our class gallery of goldfields voices.

The Source Pack

Historians never write from imagination alone. Whenever your writing needs a true detail, dig here. Every fact below comes from historical sources about the Australian goldfields of the 1850s.

Women on the diggings

On the Ballarat goldfields in 1854 there were 4,023 women living alongside 12,660 men; by 1861 there were more than 9,000 women. Most women ran the home: cooking over a fire, cleaning, sewing and mending. Washing day was the hardest, scrubbing mud-caked clothes by hand against a washboard. Women made their own bread, jam, soap and candles. Some ran shops, hotels or boarding houses, made clothes and hats, and a successful store could earn far more than most diggers. A few women dug and panned for gold themselves.

Children on the diggings

Children fetched water, gathered firewood, fed animals, washed clothes and minded younger brothers and sisters. Older children panned for gold and worked the rocker. School was not required and cost money, so many children never went; some families sent their sons but kept their daughters home. The first classes were held in tents that moved when the miners moved. In their spare time children played marbles, quoits, spinning tops and knucklebones (real bones from sheep joints). The whole family shared one tin tub of bath water, once a week. Disease was most dangerous of all for children.



SOURCE DETECTIVE: “Old Ballarat as it was in the summer of 1853-54”, painted by Eugene von Guérard, who lived and dug there. This is the very place and year your story happens. Borrow a true detail from it.

Everyday survival

The staple meal was mutton and damper, with black tea boiled in a billy and drunk from a tin pannikin. Meat spoiled fast without refrigeration, so it was rubbed with salt to preserve it. River water was polluted and had to be boiled before drinking. Sickness such as dysentery and typhoid spread easily, and doctors were too expensive for most, so miners visited apothecaries, who mixed medicines from plants. Mining itself was dangerous: collapsing shafts, machinery and bad air in the tunnels. In Ballarat in 1859, on average one miner was killed in an accident every week.

Chinese miners

By 1861 more than 38,000 Chinese people lived in Australia, and over 12,000 arrived in the year 1856 alone. Most were working to pay back the cost of their voyage before returning home to family in China. They worked in well-organised teams of 30 to 100, patiently reworking claims that other diggers had given up on, and often found gold others had missed. Many were skilled farmers who planted market gardens and grew the fresh vegetables the whole diggings relied on. They faced unfair extra taxes, suspicion and violence: at Buckland River (Victoria) in 1857 and at Lambing Flat (now Young, New South Wales) in 1860-61, rioters attacked Chinese camps and burned their tents. Afterwards, NSW passed a law to limit Chinese immigration.

Prices and money (*with rough values in today's dollars*)

Item	Cost then (and today)
A miner's licence (every month, gold or no gold)	30 shillings (about \$350)
Most diggers earned, per week	£2-3 (about \$300-450)
One egg	sixpence (about \$7)
A loaf of bread	up to two shillings (about \$45)
Butter, per kilogram	a luxury (about \$200)
A simple restaurant meal	more than a digger earned in a day



THE DREAM: the "Welcome Nugget", found at Ballarat in 1858, weighed almost 69 kilograms. Finds like this kept a hundred thousand people digging. (Museum replica.)



WHERE IT LED: "Swearing allegiance to the Southern Cross", painted by Charles Doudiet, who was there, Ballarat, 1854. You will meet this story in class: the Eureka Stockade.

About the pictures in this booklet. All paintings and photographs are from Wikimedia Commons and are in the public domain: Edward Roper, "Gold diggings, Ararat" (1854); "An Australian Gold Diggings" (c. 1855, unknown artist); "Canvas Town, South Melbourne" (1850s); S.T. Gill, "Canvas Town" (1852); a Victorian gold licence (1850s); an Australian gold nugget; "Gold diggers using a puddling machine at Bendigo"; Thomas Balcombe, "Edward Hargraves" (1851); "Chinese Gold Miners" (19th-century photograph); Eugene von Guérard, "Old Ballarat as it was in the summer of 1853-54"; the Welcome Nugget replica; Charles Doudiet, "Swearing allegiance to the Southern Cross" (1854). Images load from Wikimedia when this page is opened with an internet connection.